I started sweating about this newly assigned responsibility as I walked to my room. There were no GPS devices in those days, so pilots had to familiarize themselves with the map and the actual terrain for navigation. Scenes from the previous sortie to this helipad started flashing in front of my eyes. But more than a year had passed, and it was all too blurry. I had assured the flight commander for two reasons—it was a casevac, so someone's life was at stake, and it was also an opportunity for me to prove myself.

No sooner had I entered my room than I took out the map of the valley and started going through it carefully. When I had gone to this helipad before, I had gone with a senior pilot who had earlier been there. The responsibility of navigation had not fallen to me then. And there was no war going on back then. If one crossed the LoC now, things could get worse. After all the necessary preparations on the map were done, I went to sleep. I had to wake up fresh the next day. But even after a while, I felt myself struggling to sleep as thoughts about what could go wrong flooded my mind. It was then that I remembered what the captain of my previous sortie to this helipad had taught me—something that would hold me in good stead the next day.

There was a particular turn in this valley where pilots usually got confused. The key to not getting confused was timing. In flying, when a pilot takes off he/she is supposed to bring the aircraft to a particular height and then set the course at a constant speed. This constant speed and distance to the helipad could be used to calculate the time it would take to reach that confusing turn to avoid any trouble. Since the flying distance to that helipad was not much, the time required for this calculation was also very less. But now I knew what I had to do. Soon, I fell asleep.

The next day I woke up even before the alarm went off. I prepared myself for the sortie and went to the helicopter. This mission had no margin for error. No time for a recce would be available once airborne and the luxury of hovering over the area to spot the helipad was not there due to its location very close to the LoC.